וַיִּחַן שָׁם יִשְׂרָאֵל נֶגֶד הָהָר (19:2), possibly the most beautiful pasuk in the Torah. רש"י comments כְּאִישׁ אֶחָד בְּלֵב אֶחָד. However, people often overlook the next pasuk: וּמֹשֶׁה עָלָה אֶל הָאֱלֹקִים. The ספר דרש והעיון, quoted in מעינה של תורה, offers a profound insight: if כלל ישראל achieves this tremendous אחדות and can stand against the יצר הרע, symbolized by a הר, then their leaders, like משה, can ascend higher, reaching הקדוש ברוך הוא - וּמֹשֶׁה עָלָה אֶל הָאֱלֹקִים. He was able to rise higher because of them.

This ascension represents a new challenge. Each step in life, whether in success or failure, presents challenges. When we fail, the challenge is to overcome and improve - through תשובה, תפלה, צדקה, or other means. However, when we succeed, the challenge is not to rest on our laurels. Instead, we should use success as a springboard to elevate ourselves further, continually striving to reach greater heights. Reflecting on the infinite nature of הקדוש ברוך הוא and the spiritual heights reached by גדולים like משה, רש"י, and the Vilna Gaon, we realize the potential within us. Even a simple bank teller like רב קהתי achieved greatness through his פירוש on משניות, demonstrating that ordinary people can reach extraordinary spiritual levels.

This theme ties into an enlightened teaching quoted by R' Matis Blum זצ"ל, (known for his תורה לדעת sheets), from the sefer חנוכת התורה החדש. He references a Gemara in שבת דף פ"ח ע"ב: בְּשָׁעָה שֶׁעָלָה מֹשֶׁה לַמָּרוֹם - when משה went up to שמים; אָמְרוּ מַלְאֲכֵי הַשָּׁרֵת לִפְנֵי הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא - the מלאכי השרת, who serve before Hashem, complained. רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם, מַה לִּילוּד אִשָּׁה בֵּינֵינוּ - Why is a בשר ודם, a person born of flesh and blood, coming here amongst us? הקדוש ברוך הוא אָמַר לָהֶן - answered them; לְקַבֵּל תּוֹרָה בָּא - He came to accept the תורה, to receive the תורה. They responded with the pasuk in תהילים (8:2): תְּנָה הוֹדְךָ עַל הַשָּׁמָיִם - Leave it up here with us. So what did Hashem do? He didn't say yes or no. He turned to משה and he said הַחֲזֵיר לָהֶן תְּשׁוּבָה - Answer them. That's how we translate it. Give them a תשובה, an answer. So משה רבינו said an astounding thing to Hashem: רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם, מִתְיָרֵא אֲנִי שֶׁמָּא יִשְׂרְפוּנִי בַּהֶבֶל שֶׁבְּפִיהֶם - I am terrified. I am scared that they are going to burn me up with their fiery breath. So Hashem said אֱחוֹז בְּכִסֵּא כְבוֹדִי וַחֲזוֹר לָהֶן תְּשׁוּבָה - Hang on to my כסא הכבוד and give them תשובה.

The entire interaction in this Gemara is astounding. What is happening here? What does this שַׁקְלָא וְטַרְיָא reveal? What were the מלאכים asking, and how did משה רבינו respond?

On a basic level, we know the story: the מלאכים opposed the תורה being given to humanity. However, the חנוכת התורה החדש provides a deeper insight. The מלאכים argued that Man, inherently driven by a strong יצר הרע, would inevitably commit עבירות and neglect the תורה. They believed that leaving the תורה in שמים would be more appropriate. Hashem's response to משה, חֲזוֹר לָהֶן תְּשׁוּבָה, meant not only to provide an answer, but also to highlight the concept of תשובה itself. Through תשובה, a person can rectify עבירות. However, משה expressed fear, שֶׁמָּא יִשְׂרְפוּנִי בַּהֶבֶל שֶׁבְּפִיהֶם. משה was still concerned about the מלאכים's spiritual superiority and purity, as they are free from עבירות and exist in complete טהרה.

Hashem's instruction to משה, אֱחוֹז בְּכִסֵּא כְבוֹדִי, symbolizes the profound idea that תשובה can elevate a person to incredible heights. As חז"ל teach, תשובה reaches the כסא הכבוד, placing גדולה תשובה שמגעת עד כסא הכבוד - בעלי תשובה on a higher מדרגה than those who never sinned. This is difficult for us to fully grasp, but it emphasizes the transformative power of תשובה.

The next pasuk in תהילים (8:3) says, מִפִּי עוֹלְלִים וְיוֹנְקִים יִסַּדְתָּ עֹז. משה רבינו told the מלאכים, "I have an answer for you. I can hold on to the כסא הכבוד and reach a higher level than you." The מלאכים dismissed this, arguing, "We don't buy it. We're on a higher level because we have no עבירות. We are completely sin-free, pure in every aspect. Your נשמה is stained by עבירות." In response, משה רבינו confidently countered, "No, I can still surpass you. How? Through the הֶבֶל שֶׁבְּפִיהֶם - the pure words of תינוקות של בית רבן, our קינדערלאך." Another famous מדרש reinforces this idea: when the מלאכים initially resisted the תורה being given to us, various guarantees were proposed - the אבות, the אמהות - but the מלאכים remained

unconvinced. But when they promised תינוקות של בית רבן, the קינדערלאך, the מלאכים accepted them as guarantors and allowed us to get the תורה. When we promise that we'll teach our קינדערלאך and they will be able to learn תורה in purity without any עבירות, that is the הבל.

We have both the בעלי תשובה and the הבל שבפיהם. That's what the pasuk says עֹז מִפִּי עוֹלְלִים וְיוֹנְקִים יִסַּדְתָּ - The תינוקות של בית רבן are the answer to the מלאכים and enable to receive the תורה. Im Yirtzeh Hashem, in the זכות of קבלת תורה, may we all be זוכה to do תשובה and return back to being עוֹלְלִים וְיוֹנְקִים. Let us all be in our childlike acceptance of קינדערלאך הקדוש ברוך הוא with complete אמונה and בטחון. In that זכות, let משיח come quickly and everyone should have ישועות ונחמות.

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